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Junior Mance

Pianist Junior Mance was born in Chicago in 1928. He studied at Roosevelt College and gained early experience with Gene Ammons and Lester Young. During his military service, Junior played with the Adderley brothers, later joining their quintet in 1956. He has recorded and toured with Dizzy Gillespie, Dinah Washington and Joe Williams and currently leads his own trio. The strong blues influence in his playing makes him immediately recognizable and he has composed a number of classic jazz tunes, including "Harlem Lullaby."

Junior Mance was interviewed by Michael Woods and Monk Rowe in New York City on July 27, 1995.

MR: We are here today filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, with Dr. Michael Woods from our faculty, and we have the pleasure of the company of Mr. Junior Mance, who is a veteran pianist, teacher, composer, expert on the blues, and it's a great pleasure to have you here. Welcome.

JM: Thank you. It's a pleasure to be here.

MR: I'd like to start off asking you what you're up to now.

JM: Well now I'm up to several things. I'm still performing with my own trio and I'm recording for Enja Records. It's spelled E-N-J-A, over here they say "Inja," but in Europe they say "Enia." And also I've been, before that I decided, in fact I had two records come out at the same time, one on Enja and one on Chiaroscuro.

MR: Which we have with us today for your autograph.

JM: But I'm contracted to Enja now. And I just got back from Japan on a tour that is called "100 Gold Fingers," it features ten piano players — Hank Jones, John Lewis, Kenny Barron, Ray Bryant, Gene Harris, Joanne Brackeen, Roger Kellaway, and who have I left out, oh, Cedar Walton and myself. And there was one more. Ten of us.

MR: Sounds great.

JM: And it's a tour we make every other year, sponsored by Fujitsu, you know, the computer company. And it's really a nice thing too. We play nothing but concert halls, you know, and we get the best pianos, mostly Steinways.

MR: How many of you play at once?

JM: Never more than two at a time. They have one bass player and one drummer. Bob Cranshaw is the bass player and Alan Dawson usually is the drummer but he was put in the hospital shortly before we left, I think he's going to be all right though, and Grady Tate made it this year. And the way they do it, you know like six guys will play alone, I mean, each one of them will play alone for about twelve or fifteen minutes with the rhythm section, which usually makes up about two tunes. And then there's an

intermission. Then the other four. There are two piano duets with or without the rhythm section at their own desire, whatever they want to do. And it changes up every night. The next night there is a different six in the front and a different four and it goes on like that. And the finale we usually choose a composer that's usually Ellington and sometimes it's just standards, you know, well-known standards, and everybody will play one or maybe two choruses of their favorite by that composer. And it ends up with Ray Bryant doing a real, for want of a better term, hot rendition of "Take the A Train," but I mean he does it with a boogie woogie bass and then the rhythm section. It's a really great finale, a great way to end it. And they videotape it every year and they record it, it comes out on a double CD. Every other year I should say they do that. And that's one that we all look forward to, you know. And the good thing about it, there are no ego problems at all, you know. Usually when you get a bunch of all stars you know you're going to get some kind of egos right, you know, who's going to get top, none of that. It's like a team. You know we not only are playing together there but we're like hanging out together, you know, away from the concert hall. It's really a nice thing. And they make everything just so great for you. The travel conditions are all first class, the hotels are all first class. The tour is usually three to four weeks. It was about four weeks this year because they added Seoul, Korea, which is just getting in on the jazz thing now you know. And in fact the only thing, I was told that the only big jazz thing they had before that was the Philip Morris Super Band, I know you're familiar with that, aren't you?

MR: I've heard of that, yeah.

JM: Yeah, and the last time they had that was two or three years ago. So they had this marvelous performing arts center, on the order of Lincoln Center here. But the main hall, which holds about 3,500 people had standing room only you know. And you would have thought it was a rock concert the way they responded you know, just straight ahead jazz and it was really wonderful. You know, so new ground has been broken in Korea.

MR: That's great.

JM: And then I've been working with another group called Lionel Hampton and the Golden Men of Jazz, which is an eight piece all star group. It changes from time to time but usually it's Al Grey on trombone, Clark Terry and Harry "Sweets" Edison on trumpets, James Moody usually on tenor saxophone, Grady Tate usually on drums, and Milt Hinton or Jimmy Woode on bass. You know and that's you say "Golden Men" because we're all over 60. I think that's the criteria for being a member of this group. But they do mostly all the jazz festivals in the summer. We were canceled this year because Lionel had another mild stroke just before we were supposed to leave. He's okay now, he's out of the hospital and but he's a tough old man. He's 87 years old and that was his second mild stroke since March and the third in the last three years. And he's doing two things, you

know, he's still got his big band going. The 29th of this month he's going to do a gig with his big band. I said, oh, boy, I hope he doesn't have another one, because we're supposed to do some things in September. We're going to a big jazz program at the Hollywood Bowl in Los Angeles and they also are going to honor him again at the Kennedy Center in Washington, D.C. And then other than that, well when school starts I'm a part time teacher. Whenever I'm there I teach. Because the faculty is made up of working jazz musicians and it's what they want. It's what most of the schools around here have. And so it's even in our contract if we have to take off for a tour or a job or something, we are free to do so, just provide a substitute, which is very easy. Usually we're able to get somebody in-house to do it. But we can get someone from outside. And I like that. I've been doing it for six years. I teach a blues class. You know, and it's a lot of fun. First I declined, I said no I'm not a teacher, I'm a college dropout you know, I said I don't have the credentials. They said "good, we don't want teachers, we want performers. See because we don't want to turn out more teachers, we want to turn out performers." So most of the classes are performing, you know, very little textbook work you know, in fact there are hardly any, the only textbook they have is this so-called, I know you're familiar with it, Mike, the "Real Book." And we have to explain to them that to just use this as a guide, because there are many, many wrong changes. But it's the best thing for them to go on, really, so it provides a guide. Anyway, that's the textbook.

MW: Let me ask you a question about this blues class. Tell me some of the things you teach people to sensitize them to play the blues with a feeling.

JM: Well, that's a big problem, sensitizing them to play the blues. Well to begin with, they have to be sophomores to take this class. In order to get into the blues they have to have a musical background anyway, I mean everybody is auditioned. You can be a hell of a classical musician or something but if you don't know the basics about playing jazz, you know they tell you well go and get that together and then come back. So as I said, when they asked me to do it, I said how do you teach anybody to play the blues? They said oh, I'm sure you'll find a way. But what I do is I usually start off to see if they know all the forms like the 12-bar blues form or the 8-bar blues form, 16-bar blues forms, you know and I go by like from what I've heard different blues singers, the structures that they sing off mostly, you know, all the old timers. And I make up chord sheets, you know and I pass them out to everybody so that they all have them to get familiar with. Because many, many 12-bar blues forms, there's a lot of them, there's the minor blues and then there's three or four different kind of minor blues forms. And three or four different ways of doing major blues. And I start with that which usually doesn't take long, because usually they are advanced enough to know that and they have no trouble reading the chord sheets. And the rest is all performing. And there is usually two or three singers in the class. And I

use a lot of records, I bring records to class, we have equipment there to play records or CDs on, and usually I've been lucky so far, most of them when they get there they know what they want, where they're going, they know what they want. They're not just strictly a neophyte as far as the word "blues" is concerned. And so and I love it. They told me, they says, well try it for a few weeks and if you don't like it we will understand. I've been there six years and going into my seventh year, and it's really great.

MR: How did you learn about the blues?

JM: I grew up in Chicago.

MW: That's a big blues town, isn't it?

JM: That's right. It always has been. You know you talk about Chicago blues, nowadays I think it's a misnomer. I'm not putting down the guys who are doing it now, you know, but the Chicago blues is really, when I was growing up, because that's when people like Memphis Slim and Muddy Waters were still living there in Chicago. You know, and they had all the joints on the South Side. And I don't use that word loosely, I mean it, "joints" you know is like what they were playing in. And they had all these great blues singers and they were recording too you know, it's just a shame that they got recognition so late in life you know. Now it's a big thing. Now they are superstars, they are superheroes.

MR: Not that many of them are still here, that's too bad.

JM: That's true too. B.B. King, I'm glad he's still around. B.B. King has opened a blues place, a blues club in Los Angeles that's doing fantastic. And he has all the guys, some of the forgotten guys, he'll give them a booking there. And in Chicago, Buddy Guy has a club there also now you know. And most of them, they call it Chicago blues, but they're mostly youngsters who, when I listen to them, most of them are imitating. Some are influenced. You know there is a difference between being influenced and imitating. But they are still young, and maybe because when I was growing up I heard that real gut thing, and that's what I'm missing when I listen to them now in Chicago. I did a record date once, why they asked me to do it to be honest I don't know, with Buddy Guy and Junior Wells. Junior Wells is the harmonica player, you know the blues player. And these guys were so earthy, so steeped in it. Because I thought I knew everything about the blues. That's the only time in my life I ever felt inadequate playing. But it was fun though. And the record sold a lot. It's called "Buddy and the Juniors." It's just been re-issued on CD also. But I stayed in the background as much as possible, because they were playing and, as they say, showing off.

MR: I mean did you feel like you had too much, I don't know how to put this, too much knowledge from your bebop playing?

JM: That could be it. I felt like I was playing too much because you know, like when you get in the habit of playing like the modern changes, or as you say, bebop, it doesn't fit with

what they're doing. You've got to think one-three-five, you know what I'm saying? You don't deviate from that one-three-five or one-four. And you stay in that bag all the time. You can't play those slick changes like Charlie Parker was playing you know.

MW: I wanted to ask you something.

JM: Sure.

MW: Do you feel that you have to trade, sometimes trade-off usages of specific parameters. For instance, if you didn't have all that harmonic sophistication, but you had to endow the music with something, you would do more with the subjective realm — more bending of notes, more blue notes.

JM: In the realm of the blues, yes, I think so. Yeah.

MW: You know you trade-off one thing for the other.

JM: Yeah, you have to. Yes. Because when I was with, I think it was Atlantic Records, they threw another curve at me. It was this, oh what was her name, she was a gospel singer, Marion Williams, used to have a group called the Stars of Faith. And she was strictly out of the church. And so they were making, it was strictly a Gospel album. It wasn't a jazz album you know. And so Bill Fischer, who is an arranger around town, a very good arranger too, he did like just some simple charts and outlines you know, like chord things. And he had to keep telling me, "Don't play the sixth. Leave the sixth out. Stick to the one-three-five, you know, the church chords." And that is hard to do when you're used to doing it. And I would just do it without thinking. I says, oh, boy, every time they had to do another take it was my fault.

MR: Oh, man, you should tape one of your fingers together.

JM: And I don't know why, they had this idea that I played in the church. I never played in the church, but they think because I play the blues a lot, because I like the blues, I love the blues you know, that they think that I had to have come out of the church. No I never played in the church.

MW: Okay, now this is a misnomer, but a lot of people just take it for granted that almost I would say seventy percent of today's African American talent came out of the church.

JM: Yes.

MW: Now I'm one that did, but not always. And then another thing, you said this, they said because you played the blues they thought you played in church.

JM: Yes. They always think that one spins off the other.

MW: One guy said it like this and I want your take on it. He said the only difference between Gospel and blues is one guy is talking about God and one guy is talking about his girlfriend. He said God and girlfriend.

JM: He's right.

MW: You know one guy's talking about God is good to me and the other one's talking about my old lady put me down. But it's the same chords.

JM: Yeah. It's the same chords but a different voice, different way.

MR: They are saying different things.

JM: But there are people too, like I worked with Dinah Washington for two weeks. She played in the church you know, and sang in it too. She also played piano. Because the good thing about working with her, you know she would sometimes show me what chords she would prefer to others, but they were never like just a simple one-three-five type chords. She knew the others too. Sarah Vaughan was another one who played and sang in church, and she was a piano player once, a lot of people don't know this, in Earl Hines' band, when he was conducting. She was a piano player and singer, but he usually had like two spinet pianos back to back. I remember in Chicago I went to see her and they had that you know.

MR: Well I was listening to an interview of yours on one of your records in "Jazzspeak," and you were talking about how you learned from your father and —

JM: In a sense, yeah. My father never played piano professionally. When I was oh I guess around five years old we moved to this apartment in Evanston, which is actually where I grew up, in the suburbs of Chicago. And whoever was there before us, just left this big old upright, you know, I mean big too. Uprights were like about six feet tall it seems like. It was probably too big and the person didn't want to be bothered with moving it elsewhere. So my father had a good ear for music. He liked music. He listened, and he was very fond of big band music, like especially the Basie band. He thought there was no other band like the Basie band. And blues, my mother was more partial to blues. So my father was just fooling around on it, and he started taking lessons. Because by coincidence, the guy that lived down the stairs under us was a piano teacher. So he taught my father a few of the basics. You know my father would do it and I would just listen to him, and not even thinking about playing the piano. So when he was at work in the daytime, I would go to the piano with one finger and pick out these melodies you know. And one day he came home early and there I was. And he was listening. So you know when you're a little kid you don't know if you've messed up or what. So right away I says, "Dad, could I take piano lessons, I'd like to learn how to play piano." And it floored him. Like what kid asks his parents if he wanted to take lessons? So he did, but he found me a better teacher than the one down the stairs. The guy down the stairs was more or less just taking people's money, you know just teaching people that just wanted to know, you know making sense of these books, you know, learn how to play in five easy lessons. And so I went on from there. I really got to like it. And I had a great teacher. In fact my first piano teacher was the best of any teacher I ever had. He was, well he died a few

years ago, he was more or less a cocktail lounge type piano player. But the knowledge he had, his heroes, were like Art Tatum, Teddy Wilson, Earl Hines in that order. You know so that was, those were the guys that I heard early in my career. And so what better three to listen to, to start off, you know, and he would play their records, you know like 78s back in those days you know, and they also put out these books of their solos, which some of them were impossible to read. I'm still not the greatest sight reader in the world you know, I've told the guys that. I read, but it's more like spelling. But anyway, we went from that, and then my mother, liking the blues so much, she had all the boogie woogie records, like by Pete Johnson, Albert Ammons, Meade Lux Lewis, who also were living in Chicago then, those three. And ironically, I got my bebop chops from Albert Ammons' son, Gene Ammons. I joined his band when I was seventeen.

MR: Oh, the sax player.

JM: Yeah, right.

MR: I didn't know that.

JM: But anyway, so for a while there, I guess almost to the time I learned bebop, I was a boogie woogie piano player. And not exclusively though, because I remember when I was about, oh about twelve years old I guess, we had moved to another place. My father took the piano with him too, he didn't leave it there. And upstairs over us was a saxophone player, who had a gig on weekends. And his piano player got sick like just before the gig. And there was only three pieces, piano, drums and saxophone. Now he had to have something you know to fill in with the piano. So he didn't know what to do. So he asked my father, he says, "Let me take Junior on the gig." I guess he figured well as long as somebody's there. It wasn't a jazz club, it was like one of those they used to call it "road houses," you know out on the highway, and nobody's paying that much attention anyway. So I went and that night he taught me how to accompany the horns and everything. It was a style they call "moonshine," you know like it as [scats] type of accompaniment. And he showed me the chords to play. Because most of the things he played were either blues chords or "I Got Rhythm." In other words, the basic things all jazz musicians should learn to begin with. So I learned it there, and then I wound up keeping the gig all summer.

MR: Wow. And you were how old?

JM: Twelve. And when school opened again I couldn't do it. But I learned a lot though. You know and then I learned other tunes too, like getting away from the "I Got Rhythm," and the blues thing. And then along came bebop. Why did they ever teach me that? I haven't been the same since — still trying to learn.

MW: Tell us, you did some work with the Adderleys.

JM: Yeah. I was in the Army with Cannonball, Cannonball and Nat.

MW: First of all I got to say if I had to pick a quintet that just to me had a beautiful jazz feeling and a beautiful soul feeling it would be the Cannonball quintet.

JM: You know, strange you mention that because this last week, Verve Records called me and sent me two cassettes they're going to re-issue. They bought the catalogue I think, the old catalogue from Mercury on those sides that we did that you're talking about and they're going to put them out in a double CD. And they sent them to me to listen to and clarify like some of the, there were a lot of errors as far as composer credits, and that's why they sent them to me along with the sheet with the thing on it, which I had those records once, I had them in vinyl. A couple of them I got back because Mercury re-issued a couple of them themselves. But it was really great to hear them again, you know, like a nostalgia. It's going to be two CDs featuring like three albums, "Cannonball's Sharp Shooters," and Nat's album "To The Ivy League" and there was one more "Cannonball En Route" I think is the name of it. But anyway, I was in the Army with those guys. And that's a funny story too. I couldn't get into the Army band because I didn't play a marching instrument. You know back then to get into the Army band you had to play a marching instrument. So I was slated to go to Korea. So the basic training you know, they give you a rifle, an empty rifle, and they teach you how to walk the guard duty. So the post they assigned me was around the service club. And while I'm walking around it, I hear this great music. I said wow, some fantastic records. You know I just assumed it was records, I wouldn't expect to hear anything like that on an Army post. And I would walk slow every time I got past the time I got near where the music was coming from. I'd walk very slowly. And you know the way you walk guard duty now I mean you walk two hours and rest one hour. And I said well during my rest period, I'm going to listen to some music, because I was I guess in about my sixth week of basic training. And the only thing I heard musically was five o'clock in the morning these hillbillies waking up with these twanging guitars and transistor radios, and fights breaking out, "Turn that stuff off!" So anyway, when my rest period came I ran back to the service club, and when I ran inside I looked and there is this big band sitting on the stage with this roly poly guy leading it, playing alto. I stopped and I was frozen. I listened and I just ran up to the stage then and I listened to a couple of tunes. And something I'd never do is ask to sit in. I always wait to be asked you know. But then I couldn't hold back. I says, "Hey man, could I sit in with the band?" So the piano player, I was standing near him and he heard me. So he reaches down off the stage and pulls me up and says, "Hey yeah man, play." And he disappeared. Now the piano player was a clarinet player who just knew some piano chords. And he had a date in Louisville. This was in Fort Knox, Kentucky. And he was late for his date, having to play this gig. So he disappeared. So there I am sitting there, they've all got civvies on, because you know, during the Korean War in the States, after four o'clock

you could put your civilian clothes on, on any Army post in the States (not overseas). But I'm sitting there, you know I'm walking guard duty with combat boots, helmet, cartridge belt, and so Cannonball's giving me like such a look of disdain, I've never seen in my life, like wow, who is this cat? And the rest of the guys in the band are looking like, "Huh?" So Cannonball asked, he says, "What do you want to play?" I says, "Well play anything out of your book." And by saying it like that, you know, that kind of caught him. It kind of surprised him, like maybe the guy is a musician. So they called an easy tune, an easy bebop tune with blues changes. They played the head and then they gave me the first solo. Cannonball says, "All right you got it." I said what did he say that for, you know I haven't been near a piano in six weeks. I just played and I stretched out and he started, "Yeah man, play some more." And I looked, and I happened to look up at the rest of the band and I see heads going like that. And after a while they say, "Yeah, yeah man, go ahead, go ahead." I must have made about nine choruses. Then the band came in and I read the charts and all. And so after that was over, Cannonball comes over to the piano and says, "Yeah man, that's great, what's your name?" I say, "Junior Mance." And Sonny Stitt was one of his heroes man, and I had worked with Sonny and Gene before I got drafted. Sonny Stitt and Gene Ammons. So he says, he laughs, he says, "If you're Junior Mance what are you doing here in those clothes?" I said, "What are you doing here?"

MR: Nobody was there by choice, right?

JM: So we had a big laugh about it and he says, "Are you coming to the band?" I said, "No, they won't let me because I don't play a marching instrument." So I finished the night, that happened to be their last set that last hour. So the next day was the day that I'm on the infiltration course, you know what the infiltration course is, that's when you're out in training and they shoot machine gun bullets three feet above the ground. The guns are fixed so that they can't do that you know. And usually it's on dry ground. Well this day they chose to take hoses and make it real muddy. And you don't stand up, you got to crawl, believe me. So when we got to the end of the infiltration course I saw this jeep. And as I got closer I says, "That's Cannonball." You know and he goes up to the First Sergeant and hands him a slip of paper and the First Sergeant just looks at it and says, "Okay, Mance, take off. They want you at headquarters." Now the First Sergeant was a big, dumb redneck, I forgot his name, I don't think he could read. He just glanced at it to make it look official. All right. So I jumped in the jeep with Cannonball, and as soon as we got out of earshot, he says, "Okay now listen carefully." He says, "These orders are phony." I says, "Oh, Cannonball you know I didn't come out here to go to jail. I was late getting there anyway because I was on the road with you." He says, "Trust me." What choice have I got? So then he says, "We're going back to the barracks and I want the

band director to hear you," he says, "maybe we can do something, pull some kind of strings to get you in the band." I says, "Oh great, well I'm for that." So we went back, and the band director didn't know about anything but marches. He was like a career soldier anyway, getting out soon fortunately, and all he knew was marches. He didn't know anything about jazz. So Cannonball had stacked the deck. When we got back to the barracks, I didn't know he had told the guys, "Now when Junior starts playing, whoop it up, you know, snap your fingers, make it look like that he's good." So I got back and the band director says oh the usual thing like your name and how long you been in the Army and so forth. He says, "Well play something. Let me hear you play something." I said, "What should I play?" He says, "Play anything." So I just started playing some blues, you know, at a tempo like that. And sure enough the guys jumped in. And so he's standing there you know like a real soldier, fingers in the belt and he's looking around at the reaction of the guys. So I went through about two or three songs, so he gave me one of these back-handed compliments I call them, he says, "Well you must be good, they think you are." Thanks a lot. So then Cannonball forgot to brief me on the important question, they asked me, and I didn't know how to answer it, I just had to answer it truthfully, he says, "What's your other instrument?" I said, "I'm sorry I only play piano." He says, "Oh, that presents a problem." So back to training I went, but the guy did make arrangements with my Sergeant to let me get off like about three nights a week that they played the service club, to go and play that. And I did. So one night I came, when I reported to the service club to play with the guys, they were looking a little bit downhearted because the drummer had gotten orders to ship to Germany. And he was a good drummer, they hated to lose a good drummer, but also he was the Company Clerk, which they do all the administrative work, it's the next thing out of the First Sergeant. And he usually knows everything, and I found out later why they wanted the company clerk, so that they could really be tight with, because he would warn them of impending inspections or like that you know. So I asked Cannonball I said, "Well that's a full time job, isn't it?" He said, "Yeah." I said, "Well how do you do that?" He says, "Well first you have to know how to type." I said, "I can type, I learned how to type in high school." Right away you could see light bulbs lighting up. He says, "Oh, yeah?" So man they got busy, and to make a long story short, they got busy with the band commander and everybody else, and pulled the strings, got me out of Basic Training and I had to go to Clerk Typist School for eight weeks, you know to learn Army administration, but they still let me work at night with the band. So that's how I got in. And you know it's something I'll never know, the Basic Training outfit that I was training with was sent to Korea and I only met four guys that came back out of this group. I understand that our whole company was absorbed into the 24th Infantry Division, which got caught in a hell

of an ambush over there. And I wonder, you know, like I sort of think that Cannonball might have saved my life. If it weren't for him I might not be here.

MR: That's such a great story, and we've had —

JM: It's a true story, too.

MR: Other folks we've talked to, Al Grey and, they all have little stories like that, that their whole life like took its turn because of a fortunate circumstance or someone stepping in and doing something good for them. That's great.

MW: Or just the fact that the piano just happened to be there.

JM: Uh huh. It could have been played without a piano.

MW: Real briefly, tell him what Benny Powell said about the trombone.

MR: Oh, Benny Powell as a young man, he was talking about being, was it at his uncle's house, and he just happened to lean back like a kid and there was this trombone sitting back there, and, "What's that?" And that was the whole start, because he'd been playing drums I guess, the bass drum he said.

JM: Well they tried to teach me the bass drum, once I got into the Army too, to make it look good I mean they had to put down something, you know I had to show I played something else. So one day they got a small nucleus of the band to go out to play you know troops that are finishing Basic Training. On their last day, part of the band will go out and meet them and play for them to march back to the company area, you know to sort of give them the spirit, well it's over now you know. So they said, "All right, Mance, we're going to throw you on the bass drum," because they figured that's good enough to try. So I says, "Okay" I was for it, it's easy. So what I didn't know, well what happened was we're marching back and everything is cool until we come to this big hill, and it's windy. So we're going up and I'm keeping the beat, so you can just imagine what that's like. Boom-boom-boom [gradually slows down] boom-boom-boom. And it got slower and slower. So the cymbal player, the guy who was playing the cymbals, and you know drummers, whoever the drummer is they're supposed to play all of those instruments anyway, you know like in the Army. So he says, he runs up and he says, "Mance, give me the bass drum, you're going to have the guys crawling in a minute." He says, "Here take these cymbals." I said, "What do I do with them?" He says, "Just hit them together." So now the only thing I'd seen playing cymbals before was in the 1812 Overture where there's a big guy — I ran back and took a big lick — WHAM you know. And you know the guys scattered in the band. And so the guy, he says, "Just put them under your arm and carry them." So that was the only time that I ever played in a formation. There was one other time, but I didn't dare play, I was a Company Clerk by this time, and there were two years in a row where both years the bands from Fort Knox and Fort Breckinridge and all the camps in Kentucky played between races at the Kentucky Derby.

See and I really wanted to go to the Kentucky Derby and this was a way to go, you know, I'll play and just hang out all day. So they had two cymbal players, they used a whole band. So they said, "Mance, don't you dare even try to play this." I said, "Don't worry." So I just marched with the cymbals. The only drag was I was stuck holding them all day. When I think about my Army experiences, Beetle Bailey had nothing on me. You know talking about when I was saying about the Company Clerk usually had the inside scoop on what was going down. Well one day they called, they call it an IG inspection, you know the Inspector General comes around like once or twice a year, unannounced, and they go to different camps and inspect to see if things are on the up and up and the barracks are neat and clean. So our barracks and our band, as I say, Beetle Bailey had nothing on us. Cannonball and I, we were roommates, we had a room, because I was the Company Clerk and Cannonball was a Sergeant. They had a band training unit also and he was the head of that. So in our room, we had two record players, about a hundred albums, and all kinds of records you know. We had hot plates, because when we got off the gig at night you know in the service clubs, we'd run back and Cannonball was a good cook, you know he'd open up cans of corn beef hash you know? The smell would wake up everybody else in the barracks. And everybody had all kinds of stuff they shouldn't have had. You know we were allowed to have two lockers, two tall lockers, one for your Army clothes and one for your civilian clothes. Cannonball and I had four apiece. And everybody else had at least three. But you were only supposed to have just a certain amount of civilian clothes. So I got on the intercom and said, "Hey guys, the IG is coming." So everybody had a car and the parking lot was right outside the barracks, everybody backed their cars up to the door, and we just shoveled everything that we weren't supposed to have into the trunks of these cars, and then put them back into the parking lot. And they had it together as far as getting the barracks together like that. And when the IG showed up, sure enough, everything was in order. But the funniest thing was after he left, everybody'd back the cars up again, and sorting all this stuff out. We just put it in anybody's trunk you know, it doesn't matter, we'd sort it out later.

MW: Does some of that stuff, you feel like that finds its way actually into your improvisation, the improvisation is not just the jazz, it's a lifestyle?

JM: That's right, yeah. You learn how to improvise on everything. Well it's like cooking. I like to dabble with cooking. I'm not a great cook, in fact I never cook for anybody else, but I cook for myself. But I improvise, and I've got my own things. And nothing's killed me yet.

MR: Can we move up in your career to the time you were playing with some of the great vocalists. You've accompanied Dinah Washington, and Joe Williams —

JM: Dinah Washington, Joe Williams, Johnny Hartman, Jimmy Rushing, Jimmy Witherspoon. Those are the main ones I think, that I remember.

MR: What was it like working with Joe?

JM: With Joe it was great. I knew Joe from Chicago anyway, Joe lived, I think he grew up in Chicago, he was born in Georgia. And it was a good experience working with Joe. I had my trio working with Joe, which was Bob Cranshaw and Mickey Roker and myself. And we had a good time. We had the same manager, John Levy, and he thought it was a good idea to put the two together, to solve two things. We usually played a short set before Joe came on and then played for Joe. And that was a good experience. I really liked working with Joe. Joe I think is one of the most, well he's well-known now, but even back then I think he was very under rated. Because so many other guys were just going beyond him, I mean in popularity I'm talking about. And they tried to brand him as a blues singer, which he didn't want, but he can sing the blues, I love to hear him sing the blues. But he knows how to do everything. He's a good ballad singer. In fact I remember, this was when Mike Douglas had his T.V. show and it was coming out of Cleveland then. And we did the show and then we were watching the show after it was taped, and we were watching in the credits in the beginning and it said blah blah blah, different artists, and featuring blues singer Joe Williams. And he hit the ceiling. He didn't like it. He wanted to be known as an all-around singer. But at that time, this was coming off, he was just coming out of the Basie band and he'd had those big hits, "Every Day," and "All Right OK You Win" and that's what made him, really. That's what John Levy used to try to tell him. But I had no problems with Joe or with Dinah. You know everybody is always asking me, "How did you get along with Dinah?" Great. I had no problems with her. Wynton Kelly had no problems with her. I followed Wynton Kelly on two jobs, with Dinah and with Dizzy. Yeah, Wynton was a buddy. But I never had any problems with Dinah. She gave me complete freedom as to how to play behind her. Like I say sometimes she would sit down and show me certain chords that she would like. The amazing thing about Dinah, Dinah had perfect pitch. There were some tunes she would want to start just cold with no intro, and maybe the tune before that was in an entirely different key. And she never missed. In the two years I worked with her, she never missed. Cannonball also had perfect pitch. Because he and Nat, Nat had relative — is that what they call it — and they used to make these little side bets. You know if a car horn passed, and we were sitting in the barracks or something, anyway, Cannon would say B flat. And Nat said no, no, no, no, no, that's B natural or A natural. It would be close. Cannon was always right. But Nat was close enough.

MR: Nat told us some great stories about some of his compositions.

JM: Who did?

MR: Nat.

JM: Oh, yeah?

MR: And an interviewer isn't supposed to tell his own stories, but I have to tell you that when I was a kid in high school, I used to hide under my sheets and listen to this all night jazz station. And I saw the same thing in one of your things, that you used to listen to Earl Hines. Well one night this tune came on, it was a piano, it was going [humms], and there was just something about this tune, I thought wow, it was beautiful. And they said, "This is Harlem Lullaby by Junior Mance." And I said oh I've got to get this record. So I got that record and I have to tell you that that tune is just — you really captured something there. Can you tell me when you wrote that and — I mean this must have been in the 60s when I heard it.

JM: It was in the 60s when I wrote it. I just recorded it again on an album that's coming out with a quartet.

MR: Can't wait.

JM: With Houston Person on saxophone and Alvin Queen on drums and Calvin Hill on bass. And we did it again with the horn. But what you say about under the sheets, well I guess I was about ten years old and my dad asked me one Christmas, "What do you want for Christmas?" You know I said, "I want a table radio." You know this was before they had the little battery portables and all of that. And he was shocked. He thought what does he want a radio for? Well they would listen to all the broadcasts at night, you know like Earl Hines would broadcast from the Grand Terrace. And there was another place in Chicago I think called the Garrick Show Lounge, where I remember Don Byas and J.C. Higginbotham were in a small group there. And they would catch all — you know that was the days when there were more radio broadcasts than there were records. But they came on so late and my folks wouldn't let me stay up to listen. But I'd ease up and crack the door and I'd sit there and listen. So I says I'll fix this, you know, and I asked for a radio. So they gave me the radio for Christmas. So I remember I would listen and Earl Hines would come on I'd search and I'd turn the volume down real low until I found it. Then I would get under the covers with the pillow and all, and listen to it. And every night this went on and they were none the wiser so then after it was over I'd put it back on the table you know. After it was over that was a time when mothers usually come in and tuck you in, you know, and I'd fake like I'm sleeping. Well one night, I fell asleep before the broadcast was over. The radio and me and everything is under the pillow and I'm sound asleep. So it woke me up and she pulled the pillow back and I says uh oh, this is it, I'm know I'm going to get it. She called me father in and they laughed. They said look at that. So then after that they started letting me listen, as long as I was in bed, and I could turn it on and listen to it.

MW: I share this with you so you won't feel alone. I used to do the same thing and my parents asked me what I wanted for Christmas and I said a transistor radio. And I was a little more discreet because at this time when they come out with the transistor radios, they also had earplugs. And they forbade us from listening to music after eleven o'clock. After eleven o'clock is when all the greatest rhythm & blues would come on. And so we would pretend to be asleep and we would, just before we went to sleep we would find the station that we wanted, and then we'd turn off the lights and everything, sometimes we'd even have a little flashlight under the covers to find that station. So I know what you're talking about.

JM: Yeah, earphones would have been great in those days, but I had to take the whole radio. It was a small one, I said I just want a small table radio, and it was about like that. I even remember the name of it, Arvin, A-R-V-I-N. That was the name of the radio. I guess they're out of business now you know, but it was this little, small radio.

MR: Didn't you record on a harpsichord too on that record?

JM: Yeah. That was more or less an experience, yes. It was interesting, but the thing about it, a harpsichord is such a delicate instrument. I had to do it on a separate track then they had to boost it. You can't play it along with the rhythm section, it doesn't project enough. So the easiest way, rather than them boosting it while I was playing it because the rhythm section couldn't hear what I was doing you know. So I would play it, put it on a separate track, and then they'd boost it loud enough, then they'd give the rhythm section earphones.

MW: How is the touch different from a piano?

JM: Oh, man. You just barely touch it. And that threw me too, how it's played. I was playing it with the same touch as a piano. No you just play it very feathery. Yeah. It's quite different. And they don't stay in tune very long. If you play it like you play a piano, you've got to tune it after every selection. In fact they had a tuner there that had to tune mine after every take, just to be sure. Yeah you have to play it very lightly. And then after that there were other people that played harpsichord, but they had the electronic harpsichords also, and there was no problem with that. But even before the electronic harpsichord before, do you remember Artie Shaw and his Gramercy Five? They made a record with the harpsichord and I imagine they must have done the same thing. Who was the harpsichord — I think Johnny Guarnieri was the player, yeah. They had a thing called "Summit Ridge Drive" where he had this long solo. And it was blues changes on it, and it featured mostly the harpsichord. And so I'm sure that's the way they did it, because that was before LPs, that was an old 78.

MR: Tell us about the first time you heard bebop. And do you remember what your reaction was?

JM: Yeah I remember the first time I heard it. It wasn't on — was it on records or not? I think it was probably the same time — I was in high school, or I had just graduated from high school I think, or maybe during my last year of high school. I really was getting into it. And so there was a saxophone player who was a good friend of mine who was really a Lester Young fanatic. And then he heard Charlie Parker, you know and he was talking about Charlie Parker. He says, "Oh you've got to listen to this." So I went over to his house and he had these old Dial 78s. And he played them for me, and I said wow, I hadn't heard anything like that. So then I had a gig on weekends. I was working with this band that played just, they call it traditional swing now, you know, just straight ahead jazz. And nobody played bebop. They played good, the saxophone player was like Illinois Jacquet style, the saxophone player, like Texas Tenor style, which I still love today. But the bass player, who was the leader, was very anti bebop. He was really anti bebop. In fact he didn't like the drummer, because the drummer had gotten into bebop drums, you know, like Max Roach and that. And he used to tell him, "Stop dropping those bombs." That's what he used to say, "Stop dropping those bombs." So one night, two guys came by and wanted to sit in. One was an alto player and the other was a trumpet player. They were young too, they were around my age, maybe a couple of years older, I guess they were maybe about nineteen or twenty. And so the bass player let them sit in, and the saxophone player sounded wonderful. He was like imitating Charlie Parker. And the trumpet player was playing like Dizzy, like the trumpet player, and they started calling him "Little Diz." And man, I heard this and I said wow, you know? And I loved it. And the bass player, oh he was furious. He said, "Man they're playing that garbage." He said, "Junior, don't listen to that, that'll never go anywhere. It will just phase itself out quick." So he was saying this and it just went in one ear and out the other. But I got these guys' phone numbers and I started hanging out with them. And that's when I really got into it. So after this gig was over, I got another gig with a big band in Chicago, it was called Jimmy Dale, which was a pseudonym. There was a Jimmy Dale who was an arranger, but this was not the same Jimmy Dale. Jimmy Dale used to put out stock arrangements, but this was a different guy. This was a guy named Harold Fox who had Fox Brothers Tailors. He made uniforms for all the bands that were on the road. And the band was like a Who's Who. The band was — well you know how they have the Monday night bands here like when Thad Jones and Mel Lewis used to play at the Vanguard every Monday night. Well that's the kind of band we were. So Gene was in the band, Gene Ammons. Gene Ammons was in the band, Lee Konitz was in the band, he was from Chicago, Eugene Wright was the bass player, and all the guys were just fantastic players. And we did more rehearsing than playing but we just loved getting together every week just to rehearse. And we had a book that was out-a-sight. Because what Harold would do,

Harold was a frustrated trumpet player himself. But he was a good musician, he knew about the theory of music. So he would trade bands a set of uniforms if they let him copy like some of the tunes from their book. Like we had tunes from Basie's book, and remember the Billy Eckstine Big Band? We had some of those tunes. We had a couple of Dizzy's tunes. We had a lot of Stan Kenton tunes, some Woody Herman things. The book was about that thick with all these things, you know all these charts. And we got all these great players, especially with Gene and Lee. And so we'd get together every week and the band was like tight, it was just perfect. In fact I remember once Stan Kenton came to Chicago to play a dance. In those days they had more dances than concerts. And so we got the gig for the opening act for Stan. So I don't know why Harold did this, with all of the stuff we had in the book, he played all of Stan Kenton's charts. He called all of Stan Kenton's charts. So while we were playing, you know like the cats are coming to work out of Stan's band, and here we were playing. So I looked up once and they're lined up behind our bandstand listening. And one of them yelled out "see man, that's the way that's supposed to sound." I said whoa. And Stan was, oh he was pissed. So the guys came on, and it was funny to the guys in Stan's band. And we played other things too after a while, but Stan was, oh man, he was really burned, because we played his tunes. So the next night the band had a layover for a day. We had a rehearsal. And Stan's whole band showed up at our rehearsal, just to sit in and play with us at the rehearsal. And then there were a lot of little things that they had done different in the arrangements. Like a couple of the trumpet players were working with the trumpet section, you know, there were a couple of saxophone players the same way. Stan didn't show up so I had no help.

MW: That's kind of funny and kind of beautiful also, when you talk about the way that information is shared. Because all of the information is really not on the printed page.

JM: Right. Yeah. And this is what the guys were doing when they showed up. And we had a ball. The guys loved it.

MW: And also this is something else I'd like you to say a word about, is how the music, when it's played well, creates its own camaraderie.

JM: Yes. That's true. It does. In more than one situation the same thing would happen on the 100 Gold Fingers Tour. The camaraderie that was created by the way that everybody's just really playing, and playing good. But in the case of the band we were playing and this guy just yelled out, I don't even know who it was, but I remember it was one of the guys in the band, he was sort of behind the stands, he says, "Yeah, see, that's the way it's supposed to sound."

MR: He could be looking for a job himself.

JM: I don't know if Stan was around then, but Stan got there in time to hear us playing his stuff.

MW: I want to ask you about young keyboard artists coming up today, who do you like? Who do you think carries on the tradition and has a good feel, a good grasp on the music?

JM: There are a lot of young artists today. There's a lot of them. Benny Green for one, a young piano player. And there's another one, what's this kid's name, a heavy set guy, I'll think of his name in a minute. Steven Scott is another one that I like. And then there are a lot of them who don't have big names yet. There was one I had as a student at the New School and he's recording on Verve now. He's also playing organ. That's Larry Goldings. He's another one. There are so many of them. I don't know I listen to everybody and one thing I don't do much is compare or rate students unless they just can't play. But the reason I listen to everybody, I learned this from Benny Carter years ago. Benny Carter came to New York to do a soundtrack for a terrible movie, called "A Man Called Adam." It was a Sammy Davis movie. It went nowhere. But the music was good. Benny did the score for a movie, and Mel Torme was in the movie. So anyway we were recording the soundtrack, a period of about three days I guess. And so after we finished one day's recording, Ornette Coleman was in town at the old Five Spot. And so some of the guys, the musicians, went by there and Benny was there. And he was there listening you know. And I think he stayed a couple of sets. So one of the guys says, "Benny, what are you doing here? This isn't your type of music." Benny said, "Listen, I listen to everything. It doesn't mean that I'm going to use it or that I like it. But you have to listen to everything." He says, "You have to be aware of what's going on." And so I'm the same way. I listen to a lot of things. My likes are very diversified as far as people I like. Like some of the guys, I really like Archie Shepp, the player. I do. Archie says a lot. And I like all avante garde music, that's something I do like. Because I'm basically you might say a straight ahead, bebop, blues or whatever. But I even tell the students that I say listen to everybody. Maybe there's something there you can use. You never know. Maybe it's something you can incorporate into what you're doing, to enhance it more.

MR: Do you have a favorite record of your own?

JM: No.

MR: No?

JM: That's one of my secret ambitions is to make a record that I like.

MR: Make a record you like? Oh!

JM: Don't ask me why.

MW: Are you overly critical?

JM: Huh?

MW: Do you think you're overly critical?

JM: With myself? I could be. That's what everybody says. But I don't know why I'm like that. I listen to my records like in the studio and I may listen to like the rough draft of it,

like when they give you the cassettes to take home. But when it comes out I never listen to it. I may hear it by accident like on WBGO you know, the jazz station, or something like that. But I don't play them at home. I never listen to them. I know, when you said about being overly critical, I think I might be because I used to always, I remember when I first started recording I would say now why did I do that? Why didn't I do such-and-such a thing? The only record I really liked that I ever made was my first album as a leader. After that I don't know, I just didn't like them. My first one was on Verve, it's a record called "Junior." I was playing with Dizzy at the time and Norman Granz was the producer of it. And Dizzy was also with Verve. He produced Dizzy's album and then we had just done two albums. So Norman, he liked the way I played and he asked me he says, "How would you like to make a record?" I said, "Yeah, of course." He says, "Do you mind using Ray Brown?" I says [stammers]. We had a great bass player too, Sam Jones was the bass player that Dizzy really loved and who I was going to use anyway. But Ray, he was like, he was the big man then, and I used Dizzy's drummer, a youngster, this guy was only like nineteen years old, named Lex Humphries. He was the drummer. And I enjoyed doing that album, because Norman was there, and the first couple of things we did, it went down in one take. So Norman was kind of tired that day because he had been doing a million other, I think he'd been recording some of the other people that recorded on Verve then. And he said, "Well you guys don't really need me." He says, "You can finish by yourself." So it was just the three of us and the engineer. And I enjoyed what I did. You know the engineer would listen to it and he said, "Well you like that? Are you satisfied with that?" And Ray was very helpful. Ray was saying, "Sounds good to me." Ray wouldn't even play solos, you know, I forced him into playing a solo on one of them, a slow blues, and while we were playing I just stopped and pointed to Ray. And it was such a good take at that point, so he had to take a couple of choruses you know. But the reason he didn't play, he says, "This is your date, this is your first one, you're the star here."

MR: That's great.

JM: And that went all right. But after that I don't know, I guess I was just very critical about all that I did. The one record I did on Enja, I was pretty happy with, not as happy as I was with the first one, only because the producer at Enja, in fact he's one of the owners, will only take first takes. He doesn't believe in this take it over, take it over. And I love that concept. Everything we did on this album called "Softly as a Morning Sunrise," everything is one take. Because, especially in jazz, like when you're improvising, if you do more than one take, after that it's downhill. It doesn't get better if you've got to repeat the same thing.

MW: Could I ask you a question about that?

JM: Sure.

MW: I know a lot of other jazz musicians who feel much the same way and so do I. But there are some musicians who feel that okay, if you take the first take and you're not happy with it, then your mind has already started thinking about whatever measure there was a problem, or didn't do just what you wanted it to do or whatever, and then from that point on you're really not improvising because you've memorized where the problems were and you're just, you're really just not flying after it anymore, you're just trying to repair something.

JM: Yeah. That's it exactly. You try to get too technical. Maybe you flubbed something, something that nobody knows the difference but you. And by trying to make that whatever you did, trying to make it perfect, you lose a little of this, some of the heart goes out of it, the feeling. And if you keep doing it the feeling is going, so maybe technically it's getting better. And if it gets to be too perfect, it sounds sterile sometimes.

MW: Or the emphasis completely shifts from expression to execution.

JM: Exactly. That's right. You hit it. That's it exactly.

MW: And it's chamber music. It may as well be written down.

JM: Exactly. Yeah. Because you know, it's funny, Miles Davis made the statement once he says, "Man I don't like Oscar Peterson." I say, "Why?" He says, "Because he never makes a mistake." Which Oscar doesn't. Oscar is flawless when he plays all the time. But Miles, you know Miles made a lot of mistakes, so did Bird. But to us, we figure it was supposed to be like that. It's like Steve Martin when he stumbles and falls, oh I meant to do that. Like you remember, there's a record that's really a classic, one Bird made, "Lover Man." You know this is when he was, right after that they carted him off to Camarillo, because he was losing it you know? This record sounds so great. I mean the feeling was there. He made a lot of mistakes, but he covered them up. They don't sound like mistakes. And that solo turned out to be a classic. They had more young musicians imitating that solo.

MW: Some people even will say that you come up with your best ideas when you paint yourself into a corner.

JM: Yeah. Sure.

MW: You say how am I gonna get out of this, you know.

JM: That's right. Yeah. But this producer at Enja, he says, "I want mistakes and all." He says that's jazz. And the only time he'll take a second take is like if somebody in the booth messes up, or if the tape runs out or something. But other than that, it's like recording live. Now when Cannonball signed with Capitol Records, he made a deal with them, or he had it put in his contract, that all of his sessions were going to be live, which if you notice most of the Capitol sessions are. I think this was after, one of the last Riverside

things he did was a live date, and that was the biggest hit he had. And so everything after that was done live. The last date I did for Enja, that's the one we did "Harlem Lullaby" on, that's live. And there's a difference too. You know, you've got a different set of emotions when you're playing live.

MW: I wanted to ask you about that and let you kind of expound on that for just a moment, and that would be when you play live, do you feel like there is an immediate need for communication to an audience first rather than a tape recorder? Or is there a communal degree of communication going back and forth between you and them?

JM: I think it's more of a communal thing going back and forth. The musician is spinning off of what the audience is giving him. You need that. Especially if you've got one that's in your corner all the way, you need that. There's nothing better than that. Actually I don't think much about it before I'm playing as to how they're going to react, I'm just happy that they're there. And I figure if they're there, they're there to hear us. And we normally get a good response. And that's what I feel about it. But when you're in a studio, there's nobody there but the producer, the engineer and a forest of microphones. Not much inspiration you can get off that except playing with the guys you know, with the rest of the group. But it's not the same as playing live. And you're going to make mistakes, but that's jazz. But the thing of it is, a good jazz musician, you know, in fact it's one of the things I learned from the older guys in Chicago, well to put it bluntly, one guy told me he says, "When you make a mistake," he says "forget about it. Play right through it." He says, "Just say to yourself oops, and keep going. And nobody will know it's a mistake but you." He said, "When you make a mistake, make it loud and wrong. Don't make it soft. That way it stands out like a mistake. But if you just make it loud — 'oh, look what he did there, oh, yeah, I got to listen to that again.' After that everybody else will be doing it." Like with Charlie Parker's "Lover Man."

MW: Or one person said, we were talking, I was playing with a band and we were talking about that same thing and he said, "If you make a mistake, play the same thing a third lower. Sequence it."

JM: Yeah. I never thought about that, yeah.

MR: Now we're going to hear you do that.

JM: That's the joy in playing jazz. You're going to make a mistake and then you can turn a negative thing into a positive thing. And I think this is what makes it fun.

MR: Well we've had a lot of fun here today. And I'd like to say that this has all been live, mistakes and all. But it's been a great pleasure sharing your recollections and your views on jazz.

JM: This has been my pleasure. I've really enjoyed it, really. I wish all interviews were like this.

MR: So on behalf of Hamilton College and Mike Woods, I'm Monk Rowe and I want to thank Junior Mance for sharing this time with us. It's been really great.

JM: And I want to thank you for having me.

MR: All right.